

A Friendly Chat

Weizenbaum created Eliza as a part of his study titled : “ELIZA--A Computer Program For the Study of Natural Language Communication Between Man and Machine”. The name is derived from the character named Eliza Doolittle, from the play “Pygmalion” by George Bernard Shaw. For the first creation, the psychiatrist ambience was selected because the creator felt that under those circumstances the amount of information that would be needed to be fed in to create the impression of intelligence would be small. Only 200 lines, Eliza was, nevertheless, quite intuitive since it could incite people to discuss private personal problems. Weizenbaum who was not prepared for the response his program received, was disappointed because of the negative reactions he got when it was revealed that Eliza was a program who couldn't truly understand a user.

A session with Eliza went something like :

User : I am unhappy.

ELIZA : Do you think coming here will help you not to be unhappy

User : I need some help, that much seems certain.

ELIZA : What would it mean to you if you got some help

User : Perhaps i could learn to get along with my mother.

ELIZA : Tell me more about your family

User : My mother takes care of me.

ELIZA : Who else in your family takes care of you

User : My father.

The responses were created from a set of rules which were based on keywords occurring in the user's statements. In case a response tallied with more than one rule, a random selection was made. In case there were not matches, ambiguous messages like “That is very interesting. Why do you say that?” were used. ELIZA inspired many clones, presently called “Chatbots”, and characters in games. The original version of ELIZA can be sampled at <http://chayden.net/eliza/Eliza.html> (requires Java).